

C2 – AFFORDABLE HOUSING VS RENT BURDEN & HOMELESSNESS

(Contradictions Ledger – Evidence Sheet)

I. THE OFFICIAL NARRATIVE (“WORDS”)

From 2021–2024, federal officials repeatedly told the public that they were “lowering housing costs,” “expanding affordable housing,” and “ending homelessness.”

Key examples include:

- The President promising to “cut the cost of housing” and “bring rents down” in the 2024 State of the Union.
- HUD leadership celebrating “historic strides” toward ending homelessness and expanding access to affordable housing.
- White House briefings describing “cooling rents” and “significant progress” on inflation.
- Treasury and NEC officials describing a broad “affordability agenda” and efforts to fix the housing supply shortage.
- The Federal Reserve chair pointing to “housing services disinflation” as a source of relief.
- FHFA assuring Congress that the housing finance system is “safe and sound” and “resilient.”

Together, these statements present a unified story: that federal policy is successfully making housing more affordable and bringing homelessness under control.

II. HOUSEHOLD OUTCOMES (“OUTCOMES”)

The federal government’s own data tell a very different story about what actually happened to renters and people experiencing homelessness.

1. Record Homelessness

HUD’s 2024 Annual Homelessness Assessment Report (AHAR) estimates more than 770,000 people experiencing homelessness in 2024 – the highest level ever recorded and roughly an 18% increase in a single year compared to 2023. This occurred while HUD was publicly talking about “ending homelessness.”

2. Renters at All-Time High Cost Burden

Census and Harvard Joint Center for Housing Studies data show that by 2023 about 22.6 million renter households – roughly 49.7% of all renters – were cost-burdened, paying more than 30% of their income toward housing. This is the highest count and share on record, directly contradicting claims of “lowering housing costs.”

3. Severe Cost Burden Deepens

Within that group, about 12.1 million renter households were severely cost-burdened, paying more than half of their income toward rent in 2023. That is an increase of roughly 1.5 million severely burdened households since 2019, indicating deepening housing hardship.

4. Rents Outpace Wages

Across the 2019–2023 period, median rents rose by roughly 30% while wages rose by roughly 20%. Rents grew about 50% faster than wages. Even where incomes rose nominally, housing took a bigger slice of every paycheck.

5. Shelter Inflation Stayed Elevated

Bureau of Labor Statistics data show shelter costs rising much faster than overall inflation, with shelter CPI increasing more than 6% in 2023 and remaining a major driver of inflation in 2024. Describing rents as “cooling” did not match the reality that housing costs kept climbing from already elevated levels.

6. Home Prices Detached from Incomes

Harvard's State of the Nation's Housing 2024 report shows median home prices at more than 5.5 times median household income, compared to roughly 4 times income before the pandemic. Access to homeownership became mathematically out of reach for many first-time buyers, even as officials talked about “improving access.”

III. THE CONTRADICTION

Publicly, federal leaders describe an affordability agenda: cracking down on landlords, expanding supply, lowering costs, and ending homelessness. Privately, in their own data tables and annual reports, the same government records:

- Record homelessness counts.
- Record numbers and shares of cost-burdened renters.
- Millions more households pushed into severe rent burden.
- Rents growing much faster than wages.
- Shelter inflation remaining stubbornly high.
- Home prices and mortgage costs out of reach for typical earners.

The “affordable housing” narrative has not translated into affordable housing outcomes.

One-sentence version:

While officials claimed to be lowering housing costs and ending homelessness, their own data show record rent burdens, record homelessness, and home prices that have moved even further out of reach.

IV. HARM CHANNELS

The gap between words and outcomes translates into concrete harms:

- Financial harm: Families lose growing shares of their income to rent and mortgage payments, leaving less for food, healthcare, transportation, and savings.
- Housing instability: More households face eviction, forced moves, overcrowding, and periods of homelessness.
- Health and mental health: Housing stress is closely linked to anxiety, depression, and physical health problems.
- Inequality: Rent burdens and homelessness fall disproportionately on Black, Latino, Indigenous, disabled, and low-income households.
- Educational harm: Children in unstable housing are more likely to miss school and fall behind academically.

These harms are not abstractions; they are measurable consequences of the mismatch between policy claims and lived reality.

V. APA ROUTING (AGENCY USE)

This contradiction supports multiple Administrative Procedure Act challenges:

- vHUD – Use rent-burden, severe-burden, and homelessness data to show that HUD’s celebratory language about “ending homelessness” and “expanding affordable housing” is arbitrary and disconnected from its own outcome measures.
- vFHFA – Use home price-to-income and affordability metrics to challenge FHFA’s assurances about a “safe and sound” system that in practice locks out first-time and lower-income buyers.
- vFED – Use shelter inflation and rent data to show that communications about “housing disinflation” understate the persistence of housing cost pressure on households.
- vDOL – Use the rent-versus-wage growth gap to show that wage gains do not translate to real housing security, undercutting “strong job market” narratives.
- vSSA – Use rent burden and severe cost burden data to demonstrate that benefit adjustments do not preserve real purchasing power once housing is taken into account.
- vED / vHHS – Use homelessness and housing instability data as background to show how unstable housing undermines educational and health outcomes, contrary to program goals.

This sheet provides a unified factual baseline showing how official “affordable housing” and “ending homelessness” narratives diverge from measurable housing outcomes in federal datasets.